The Seven Chickens

By AJ Jacobs

INTRODUCTION

The world of fairy tales are filled with memories of myths and legends, princes and knights, ogres and witches . . . . and in this case chickens. In cartoons today, chickens are often depicted as fussy and silly — think Foghorn Leghorn and Prissy in Looney Tunes cartoons, or Lady Cluck in Robin Hood. *They don't exactly radiate mysterious elegance. And we will continue that grand tradition in today's tale . . . . The Seven Chickens by AJ Jacobs.*

NARRATOR: Once upon a time there was a young prince who ventured into the woods in search of game. During the course of the long day, he got tired and hungry.

PRINCE: Next time, bring trail mix.

NARRATOR: Finally, as it got dark, he came across a great castle. He knocked. A king opened the door.

KING: If you're selling magazines, we don't want any. Go away.

PRINCE: Wait *(putting his foot in the door to stop it)* I am a handsome young prince who has lost his way. Could you see your way clear to sparing me the bare essentials for a night-say, a thirty-two-course meal, a dozen servants, and a suite with a roaring fireplace?

NARRATOR: The king figured this was reasonable enough. Especially for a prince. And he led him inside to the dining room, where dinner was being served. But there, the prince was shocked by what he saw. For in the chairs around the table sat seven chickens. Figuring someone had left the henhouse door open-or had taken the idea of free range a bit too far-the prince began chasing the birds out of the room.

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PRINCE: *(herding chickens)* Shoo! Scat!

KING: *(Shouting)* Stop that! Leave those girls alone!

NARRATOR: The seven chickens again took their appointed places at the table and they, along with the king, proceeded to peck away at the dishes of corn that sat before them.

KING: *(pecking at his plate and then wiping a yellow kernel from his nose)* What's the matter, boy? You haven't pecked a thing on your plate.

PRINCE: Suddenly, I'm not hungry.

CHICKEN: Awwk, buk, buk, Awwwwkkkk, cluck

KING: What's that, Florence?

CHICKEN: Awwwk, buk, buk, buk, Squawwwwwkkkk, cluck, cluck.

KING: *(laughing loudly)* Very funny. Very funny.

PRINCE: *(with wide eyes)* What just happened?

KING: Florence just told a joke. Now, son. I'm glad you came along. I've got a problem.

PRINCE: I noticed. You're a nut!

NARRATOR: The king went on to tell the prince an incredible tale of a witch who came to the castle and cast an evil spell that turned all of his loving daughters into chickens.

PRINCE: So *that's* it. Those seven chickens are your daughters.

KING: No. Six of them are my daughters. The seventh one is the witch herself.

PRINCE: Here comes the plot.

KING: Right. The spell on my daughters cannot be broken until I can discover which one of the seven chickens is the witch.

NARRATOR: Well, now, this is the sort of thing all handsome princes dream of. All he would have to do is discover which of the seven chickens was the

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witch and the king would surely reward him with the Hand of the most beautiful of his daughters. The next morning he got up with the chickens and set about his task. He watched those seven chickens like a hawk.

KING: It's no use, boy. Chickens have the nasty habit of looking just alike."

PRINCE: True, but they don't think alike. The one that is the witch thinks like a witch.

NARRATOR: With that in mind, the prince disguised himself as a beautiful maiden. He figured if he pretended he was Snow White, no witch in the world could resist.

PRINCE: *(twirling to show off his dress)* I am Snow White! I hope that there's no witch in the castle disguised as a chicken. And I hope that witch disguised as a chicken won't give me a poisoned apple.

NARRATOR: None of the seven chickens paid the slightest bit of attention, but an ogre who happened to be casing the castle did. He wasted no time in grabbing the so-called maiden and making off with her to his cave. But just then a handsome knight chanced to arrive on the scene and rushed to the rescue.

KNIGHT: Never fear, fair beauty. I shall save you.

NARRATOR: With that, he flew at the ogre and the fight was on. *(fight ensues between the knight and ogre)* The knight won out with a combination uppercut to the right jaw and a rabbit punch to the kidneys. *(pantomime this fight)*

KNIGHT: *(Grabbing the prince-in-a-dress around the waist)* Ah, fair maiden . . Your lips ... your eyes.

PRINCE: *(responds with a sharp uppercut to the right jaw and a rabbit punch to the kidneys)*

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KNIGHT: *(rubbing his face)* Oooh, I like her.

NARRATOR: The prince, whose high heels made him a bit slower than normal, finally made it back to the castle and began trying to slither out of his Snow White suit. But before he could, the chickens gathered around him, curious to see what the commotion was.

PRINCE: *(trying to remove his dress)* Girls! Not now! Go away. (he grabs a broom and starts swatting at them, hopping to shoo them away.

NARRATOR: They all scattered. All, that is, except for one. That one snatched the broom from the prince, hopped on it, and flew around the room. Now, centuries of inbreeding couldn't weed out all traces of logic from the prince's mind. Witches, he figured, like brooms. Chickens don't. That one is the witch! The spell was broken. And not only did the witch turn back into a witch, but the six chickens were turned back into the king's beautiful daughters, a little plumper and more corn-fed for the experience.

KING: My boy! As a reward, I'm going to give you any daughter you wish to be your bride.

NARRATOR: Unfortunately, however, before the prince could choose, the knight who still thought the prince was a fair maiden galloped in, swept him off his feet, and galloped away. The prince's mother had told him there'd be days like that. But she had forgotten to warn him about the knights!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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